

BEYOND THE CREST

Season 1 Storylines — Document 08

A Daytime Drama

170 episodes • Monday, January 5 – Friday, September 4, 2026

Tagline: *Every crown has a price. Every secret has an heir.*

The Shape of Season 1

Season 1 runs from Marc-Anthony's 34th birthday to Labor Day weekend on Lake Lanier, exactly fifteen years after the night he doesn't remember. The spine is one ticking clock, the Crown License deadline of 11:59 PM on August 31, and one secret: Marc-Anthony has two daughters he's never been told about.

Movement	Episodes	Air dates	What happens
I. The Covenant	#0001–#0030	Jan 5 – Feb 13	The birthday, the body in the river, the Crown License, the auditions, the elevator
II. Roots	#0031–#0062	Feb 16 – Apr 2	Valentine's slap, Broadway, the Oscars, the DNA results, the Spare Alliance
III. Blood Tests	#0063–#0101	Apr 6 – May 29	Huntington's, Alvin's return, Mother's Day, the primary, Victor's 80th
IV. The EGOT Summer	#0102–#0135	Jun 1 – Jul 17	Victor's surgery, the Tonys, Juneteenth, the kiss, the World Cup
V. Verdicts	#0136–#0165	Jul 20 – Aug 28	The Club vote, the trial verdict, the Kettle unmasked, the Allegiance Clause
VI. Labor Day	#0166–#0170	Aug 31 – Sep 4	The deal, Theodore's arrival, the finale on Lake Lanier

Tentpoles and event episodes (the 10%)

#0001 Birthday Gala • #0011 “1958” flashback • #0031 Valentine's Ball • #0051 The Oscars • #0057 Broadway Opening Night • #0063 Easter • #0088 Mother's Day / Twins' 14th • #0096 8th-Grade Promotion • #0100 Milestone • #0101 Victor's 80th • #0106 HEIRLOOM Launch • #0107 The Tonys • #0116 Juneteenth Jubilee • #0126 Fourth of July • #0133 World Cup Semifinal • #0139 “1966” flashback • #0170 Finale. That's 17 of 170, exactly 10%.

Sweeps (see Document 01, Section 9)

Sweeps	Dates	Episodes	What airs
February	Thu, Jan 29 – Wed, Feb 25	#0019–#0038	Mallory meets Desmond • RootsKit tests • THE OLD MAN SAYS: PATIENCE • Robert's 57th and Amond's 34th • Marc and Esther face off (#0030) • Valentine's Ball slap (#0031) • Broadway rehearsals • Amond's secret meeting with Martin
May	Thu, Apr 23 – Wed, May 20	#0076–#0095	Amond calls Martin • The Club application • Victoria: “Wrong answer” • Tony nominations • Alvin comes home (#0085) • Mother's Day and the twins' 14th (#0088) • Elxa destroys evidence • Primary night (#0094) • Zion Reed (#0095)

Sweeps	Dates	Episodes	What airs
July	Thu, Jun 25 – Wed, Jul 22	#0120–#0138	Victor comes home • Joan's confession • The Fourth of July kiss (#0126) • Deuce's trial begins • Alvin steals the security plan • World Cup semifinal (#0133) • T-Bone's girlfriend testifies • #MarcForPresident trends (#0126) • Marc and Esther's night together (#0138)

The Oscars (#0051), the Tonys (#0107), and Victor's 80th (#0101) stay on their real dates just outside sweeps. They are ratings events on their own.

1. The Crown License

Marc-Anthony vs. Esther Smiley: the negotiation that decides whether Smiley Corporation survives.

Players: Marc, Esther, Natasha, Leonard, Gus, Camille, Dorian

- Leonard reveals that 41% of Smiley revenue hangs on a deal expiring Aug 31, and Esther is named lead negotiator (#0003).
- Esther dodges Marc for six weeks, including the anonymous elevator (#0017), before they finally face off (#0030).
- The talks collapse (#0083), come back over late-night waffles (#0099), and turn personal (#0138).
- Marc offers a deal too generous to be business (#0160). They sign at 11:59 PM on Aug 31 (#0166).

Why it's never been done in daytime: It's the first daytime love story whose love scenes are term sheets. Every romantic beat is also a corporate move worth billions.

Status at the finale: Signed, and both families furious that it was fair.

2. Roots

Three 13-year-olds use a school heritage project and a Smiley DNA kit to discover that their “donor” father is the movie star they idolize.

Players: Emma, Victoria, Lyric, Esther, Marc, Nathaniel, Trey

- Westbrook's Black History Month Roots Project assigns RootsKit tests (#0021).
- The results match the twins to Grace Bullock: aunt or half-sibling (#0053).
- “Operation Daddy”: Lyric steals a hair (#0055), the twins mail it in (#0062), and the result is a 99.98% parent/child match (#0075).
- The anonymous Father's Day card (#0117). The twins watch Marc and Esther kiss (#0126).
- They tell him themselves in the finale (#0170).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The children solve the paternity mystery before any adult does, using a product made by their own mother's company. They run the investigation, they choose the reveal, and they deliver it.

Status at the finale: Marc knows. Esther's secret is over.

3. The Spare Alliance

The eldest grandson of each dynasty, both passed over for a younger heir, team up to destroy their golden cousins.

Players: Martin, Nathaniel, Camille, Dorian, Brielle

- Nathaniel and Camille bond over losing to Esther (#0022).
- Nathaniel sees the RootsKit flag (#0056) and takes it to Martin (#0058).
- Martin's investigator proves the IVF story is fake (#0092, #0120).

- Martin hacks the Kettle account to post the blind item (#0152). Nathaniel takes it to the Smilley Family Council (#0163).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A cross-dynasty villain team whose motive is the same wound twice: being born first and chosen second.

Status at the finale: Nova traces the hack to Martin (#0156). Marc now knows who his enemy is.

4. Who Killed T-Bone Gaines?

A murder in the Chattahoochee pits husband against wife, father against daughter, and cousin against cousin.

Players: Jeremy, Elxa, Robert, Deuce, Martin, Marc, Kane, Rosa

- The body surfaces (#0001) with “ARCHITECT” in the burner (#0002).
- Jeremy arrests Deuce, and Robert takes the case (#0015).
- The audience learns Martin did it (#0060). Peter stitched his knuckles (#0003, #0064).
- The trial (#0128–#0145). T-Bone's girlfriend swears the Architect is innocent (#0135). NOT GUILTY (#0145).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A murder mystery where the audience knows the killer halfway through, and the suspense is which family member will find out, and what they'll do.

Status at the finale: Deuce is free. The killer is untouched. Robert now knows who pays his bills.

5. The Succession Covenant

Victor names Marc heir apparent. If Victor retires, Natasha becomes Chairwoman and the CEO seat opens. Marc is the obvious choice, but nothing is guaranteed.

Players: Victor, Joan, Natasha, Jasmine, Martin, Marc, Alvin

- The Covenant (#0001). Jasmine storms Victor's study (#0002).
- Victor gives Marc the key to the 1939 press (#0009).
- Victor plans to retire at his 80th and name the next CEO (#0097).
- The 80th birthday gala: “Tonight I'm announcing my retirement, and the next CEO of The Donohue Company will be—” and Victor collapses (#0101).
- Surgery (#0102). If Victor dies in office, Section 7 hands the family's votes to Jasmine. She and Alvin start counting them (#0104).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The whole season's power struggle hangs on one unfinished sentence.

Status at the finale: Victor hasn't retired, and the CEO name is still unspoken. Theodore arrives to claim that the 1976 succession was never valid.

6. The EGOT Year

Mother and son chase the last awards they're missing in the same season.

Players: Natasha, Marc, Victor, Joan, Grace, Nia, Sebastian

- Martin smears Natasha's director on Oscar eve (#0050). Natasha wins Best Actress and completes her EGOT (#0051), and Marc crashes out on a reporter.
- Marc stars in the *Sweet Chariot* revival, the role Victor originated in 1972 (#0034, #0041, #0057).
- Eleven Tony nominations (#0084). Marc wins and completes his EGOT at 34 (#0107), dedicating it “to the family I'm going to have” (#0108).

Why it's never been done in daytime: Nobody is nerfed: in one season, the family goes from two EGOTs to four.

Status at the finale: Four EGOTs under one roof: Victor, Joan, Natasha, and Marc.

7. The Chief and the Boy Scout

The Chief of Police protects the man she thinks is guilty, her father, while her by-the-book husband hides a genetic secret.

Players: Elxa, Jeremy, Walter, Robert, Rosa, Nadia Brooks

- Elxa suspects Robert is the Architect (#0059) and destroys a ledger page to protect him (#0090–#0091).
- Jeremy's truth: his mother died of Huntington's and he has a 50% chance (#0072).
- The FBI task force (#0067). The empty warehouse raid (#0109). The marriage fractures (#0124) and they separate (#0148).
- Jeremy finally takes the test (#0155). Elxa sees Marc with Kane and understands (#0170).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A daytime heroine who is the city's top cop, protecting the wrong suspect for the right reason, while the truth is her baby brother.

Status at the finale: The results envelope sits unopened. Elxa knows it's Marc.

8. Madam President?

The Attorney General's 2028 dream versus the reporter whose father her brother killed.

Players: Arianna, Julian, Journee, Marc, Cordell Haynes, Harold & Evelyn Cummings

- Arianna announces her plans (#0005). Journee starts digging (#0014).
- **The AG primary:** Cordell Haynes files against her at 11:58 AM on the last day of qualifying (#0045), turns Journee's reporting into a campaign weapon (#0070), and asks about 2021 on live TV (#0089). Arianna wins 61% to 39% on primary night (#0094), the same night Jasmine is forced into a runoff.
- Journee meets Julian at a grief group (#0028). They fall in love (#0045, #0129).
- Arianna asks Marc to make Journee go away, and he refuses (#0078).

- Arianna learns Marc still has the car (#0144). Journee finds Julian's name (#0162), and Julian confesses (#0169).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A love story between a grieving daughter and the man who killed her father, played entirely in daylight.

Status at the finale: Arianna is the Democratic nominee for Attorney General. Journee knows. The November general election, and her secret, are on a fuse.

9. The Tea Kettle

The broke filmmaker nobody takes seriously is secretly the most-read gossip blogger in Atlanta.

Players: Harmony, Esther, Amond, Nathaniel, Martin

- The audience learns Harmony is Kettle in the final beat of #0001.
- Her posts drive the plot: the slap (#0032), the garden photos (#0089), Pryor's affair (#0112).
- Nathaniel funds her film to use her (#0071, #0142).
- Martin hacks her account to post the twins blind item (#0152). Esther unmask her and a 23-year friendship ends (#0153).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The narrator of the show's own gossip is a character inside it, and the in-universe social media is a weapon.

Status at the finale: Harmony has lost her best friend, and she knows about the twins.

10. HEIRLOOM

Grace and Mallory's beauty brand goes to war with Smilley Beauty, and Mallory falls for the enemy's grandson.

Players: Grace, Mallory, Desmond, Camille, Delphine

- HEIRLOOM is announced (#0006). Mallory meets Desmond (#0019) and learns he's a Smilley (#0029).
- Camille frames Desmond (#0069). The copycat launch on Mallory's birthday (#0106).
- Desmond clears his name and quits (#0114). Mallory decides to wait for her wedding night (#0159).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A romance where the 31-year-old virgin heiress is in full control of her story, set against real corporate espionage.

Status at the finale: HEIRLOOM survives, and Mallory and Desmond are official.

11. The Primary

Jasmine faces her first real challenge in 29 years, secretly bankrolled by the Smilleys.

Players: Jasmine, Peter, Pryor, Leonard, Alvin, Morrow

- Pryor announces (#0012). The money traces back to Leonard (#0023, #0040).
- Alvin buys Pryor's secrets from Morrow (#0093). The primary goes to a runoff (#0094).

- Kettle breaks the affair story (#0112). Jasmine wins the runoff (#0113), and now owes Morrow.

Why it's never been done in daytime: A congresswoman who wins by accepting a debt to the mob her nephew is at war with.

Status at the finale: Jasmine wins, but she owes Morrow.

12. The Vote

Sixty-four years after Simone Donohue rejected his father, Gus Smilley applies to the Club.

Players: Gus, Loretta, Joan, Victor, Lucinda

- Joan finds Gus's 1966 letter (#0039) and confronts him (#0079). The application (#0080).
- Joan confesses the romance (#0122), and Victor summons Gus (#0123).
- The “1966” flashback (#0139). The vote ties, and Joan breaks it: yes (#0140).
- Victor forgives her. “There's one more thing. About 1976” (#0158).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A love triangle between people in their late seventies and eighties, told with the same heat as the young leads.

Status at the finale: The Smilleys are inside the gates. Joan has one more secret.

13. The Wild Card Returns

Alvin comes home at the halfway point, and brings the underworld with him.

Players: Alvin, Zion, Coco, Morrow, Marc, Jasmine

- The helicopter on the lawn (#0085). The karaoke-bar meeting with Morrow (#0086).
- Zion Reed: “I think you're my father” (#0095). DNA confirmed (#0110).
- Alvin steals the World Cup security plan (#0130). Marc sets a trap (#0131). Blackwater stops the attack (#0133).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The family's party boy is the mob's inside man, and his nephew is the mob he's betraying.

Status at the finale: Alvin has a son, a debt, and a very bad feeling.

14. The Architect's Father

Robert Bullock realizes his son runs the Syndicate he's been defending.

Players: Robert, Marc, Natasha, Kane, Cyrus

- Robert takes Deuce's case (#0015) and asks Marc for BSI footage (#0098).
- The verdict, and Kane in the gallery (#0145). Robert follows the money (#0146).
- “Then act surprised when I tell you I'm proud of you” (#0147).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The father-son scene of the year is a confession with no confession in it.

Status at the finale: Robert knows and is protecting him.

15. The Old Man

Martin's mysterious backer is revealed in the final week: Theodore Donohue, coming home.

Players: Theodore, Lorraine, Xander, Celestine, Theo III, Sienna, August, Martin, Victor

- “THE OLD MAN SAYS: PATIENCE” (#0025).
- Theodore arrives (#0167) and his family follows (#0168).
- At Summit House: “Hello, little brother” (#0170).

Why it's never been done in daytime: The season-long off-screen villain turns out to be family, and joins the cast the moment the audience learns who he is.

Status at the finale: Season 2 belongs to him.

16. The Secret Candidate

The richest man on Earth, a Democrat with Republican values, secretly prepares to run for President in 2028. His best friend is running too.

Players: Marc, Esther, Arianna, Victor, Zeke Hart, Nova, Martin, Brielle

- At 11:59 PM on his birthday, Marc writes one word in a new leather notebook: 2028 (#0001).
- He asks Victor, “hypothetically,” if a Donohue could be President (#0009). Nova's secret national poll puts an unnamed “34-year-old Atlanta businessman” within six points of the Vice President (#0036).
- Zeke warns that a campaign and Blackwater can't both survive (#0046).
- After the EGOT: “What's next?” “The White House.” The room laughs, except Martin (#0108).
- His bipartisan toast for America's 250th goes viral, and #MarcForPresident trends No. 1 on Chirp (#0126). Arianna: “Tell me you're not serious” (#0127). She launches her exploratory committee early (#0129).
- Martin reads the polls: “If he runs, he wins” (#0136).
- Marc shows Esther the notebook. She's the first person he's ever told, and she's a Republican (#0150).

Why it's never been done in daytime: A soap hero whose secret isn't only a crime or a child but a White House run, built with the same patience as a murder mystery and aimed straight at his best friend's campaign.

Status at the finale: Esther and Nova know. Martin suspects. Arianna fears it. The platform is locked in the notebook, and 2028 is coming.

The Finale: Episode #0170, Friday, September 4, 2026

Labor Day weekend on Lake Lanier, fifteen years to the weekend after Marc and Esther's night. Everything collides:

- The twins walk Marc to the end of the dock: “Happy Labor Day, Dad.”
- Marc turns to Esther: “Fourteen years.” The sweetest man in the world goes still.
- Elxa sees Kane hand Marc a black river stone, and every case she ever worked rearranges itself.
- At Summit House, Theodore sets down his cane: “Hello, little brother.”
- Jeremy's Huntington's results sit unopened on the dashboard of his car.
- A gunshot echoes across the lake. Smash cut to black.

In-universe headlines, Saturday, September 5, 2026

- **The Atlanta Beacon:** “SHOTS FIRED AT LANIER ESTATE DURING DONOHUE HOLIDAY PARTY”
- **The Peach Ledger:** “SOURCES: SMILLEY HEIR'S IVF TWINS ARE A DONOHUE MATTER”
- **Hollywood Heat:** “EGOT GOLDEN BOY'S LABOR DAY FROM HELL”
- **Social media:** #LanierShooting trends No. 1 worldwide by 1:00 AM.